

Eli Tzion

411

Version 2

Trad.
Arr. Stuart Izon

Eli Tzion is the most well known dirge recited on Tisha B'Av. It compares Zion to a woman about to give birth – the birth is understood to relate to our eventual redemption. Eli Tzion is typically recited whilst standing, at the end of the morning Kinot. This elegy is of unknown authorship, but the melody is at least as old as 1743 and is ubiquitous thereafter. There does not appear to be an authoritative version; there are minor variations between different composers' arrangements – several have introduced a second part to the theme, presumably to reduce the monotony of the many stanzas. This version here is based on the tune traditionally used in England.

Intriguingly, Eli Tzion is not an especially melancholic tune. Idelsohn identified the same melody in a German Catholic hymn, a Spanish folksong, and a Czechoslovakian folksong. His conclusion was that "it originated in Spain, whence it was in all likelihood carried to Central and Eastern Europe by pilgrims; and was picked up by Jewish singers likewise".

There is a custom to use this melody for L'cha Dodi on the Shabbatot preceding Tisha B'Av. See 10w and subsequent pieces for a discussion about that practice.

Andantino

Melody Alto

8

E - li tzi - on v' - a - re - ha k' -

Tenor Bass

6

M A

8

-mo i - sha b' - tzi - re - ha v' -

T B

10

M A

8

-chiv - tu - la cha - gu - rat sak

T B

14

M
A

8

al ba' - al n' - u - re - ha a -

T
B

18

M
A

8

-lei ar - mon a - sher nu - tash b' -

T
B

22

M
A

8

-ash - mat tzon a - da - re - ha v' -

T
B

26

M
A

8

-al bi - at m' - char - fei el b' -

T
B

30

M
A

8

- toch mik - dash cha - da - re - ha

T
B